

Chapter 3: The Host

They took Eliya's body from her room.

Mara wanted to say it that way because any other version felt like another lie.

They did not take Mara.

They did not take Eliya.

They took the body they were both trapped inside.

The restraints around Eliya's wrists glowed pale and soundless, hovering just above the skin. They did not hurt. That made them feel less like chains and more like an opinion the future had formed about her.

About them.

The corridor outside Eliya's room was white stone, curved glass, and quiet rainlight. There were no sharp corners. No doors with handles. No wires. No machines with blinking lights. Everything looked too clean to be real, as if the building had grown around its own purpose.

Mara tried to look at everything.

Eliya tried not to let her.

Stop using my eyes.

"I need to understand where we are."

You need to leave.

"I already told you, I don't know how."

Then learn faster.

Kael walked ahead of them. The woman with the glass ring walked behind. The third officer stayed close enough that Mara could feel the threat of his hand without seeing it.

"Where are you taking us?" Mara asked.

Kael did not turn. "To a separation chamber."

The words should have relieved her.

Instead, Eliya went cold.

Mara felt it at once: not panic, exactly. Something older. Something educated.

“You’re afraid of that.”

Eliya did not answer.

Mara swallowed.

“What happens in a separation chamber?”

Kael finally glanced back. “That depends on how deeply you have rooted.”

“I haven’t rooted in anything.”

Eliya gave a bitter laugh inside their skull.

You touched my childhood.

“I didn’t mean to.”

You keep believing intent matters.

Mara flinched.

The corridor opened into a wide interior bridge.

The city dropped away beneath them.

For a moment, even fear lost its grip.

Eliya lived high above the ground. Far below, Archive District Seven spread across tiers of glass terraces and hanging gardens. Rain slid over transparent roofs. People moved along open walkways, their coats shifting color under the violet sky. Vehicles passed silently between buildings on invisible tracks.

And beyond the city, at the edge of the horizon, rose a ring.

It was enormous.

Not a building. Not a moon.

A silver structure arcing up from the planet and vanishing into cloud, so vast that Mara’s mind refused to accept it as artificial.

“What is that?” she whispered.

Eliya answered before she could stop herself.

The Ascension Ring.

The thought came with pride.

Then grief.

Mara caught the edge of a memory: Eliya as a child pressing her face to a window, watching lights climb the ring into the sky. A woman’s hand on her shoulder. A voice saying, One day, if you study hard enough, you’ll touch the old dark between worlds.

The memory broke.

Eliya recoiled.

Do not go there.

“I’m trying not to.”

“Both of you,” Kael said, “reduce internal conflict.”

Mara stared at him. “You can hear us?”

“No. But the body can.”

He gestured to the restraints.

Their light flickered with each spike of emotion.

“Severe conflict increases fracture risk.”

“Fracture?”

The woman behind them answered. “Identity rupture. Memory bleeding. Motor collapse. In advanced cases, one cognition may overwrite the other.”

Mara felt Eliya’s terror flare.

Overwrite.

The word stayed between them.

Mara stopped walking.

The restraints tightened without touching.

“No,” she said. “I’m not going to overwrite her.”

Kael faced her fully now.

“Most intruders say that before they begin.”

“I’m not most intruders.”

“No,” Kael said. “You are Mara Venn.”

There it was again.

That weight on her name.

Mara lifted Eliya’s chin. “Why does everyone react like that?”

Kael’s eyes narrowed. “You truly don’t know.”

“No.”

A long silence.

Then Kael said, “Mara Venn is one of the oldest names in the Accord’s intrusion archives.”

The bridge seemed to tilt beneath them.

“That’s impossible.”

“Many things are impossible before Earth does them.”

“I just left Earth.”

“Your Earth,” Kael said. “Not ours.”

Eliya whispered inside her.

Ask him what year.

Mara hesitated.

She had been avoiding it. The question felt too large. Too final.

“What year is it here?”

Kael gave the answer in Accord dating first. Eliya understood it. Mara did not.

Then Eliya's mind translated the scale.

Not perfectly. Not into a calendar Mara knew.

But enough.

Two thousand four hundred and thirteen years after Mara's departure.

Mara's breath failed.

The body kept trying to breathe, but Mara could not remember how to help it.

Two thousand years.

More than two thousand years.

Earth was not behind her.

Earth was buried under history.

"No," she said softly.

Eliya's voice came quieter than before.

Now you understand.

But Mara did not.

Not really.

She understood distance. She understood time as a number. She understood that the stars were not far away; they were old, young, out of sequence.

But understanding a theory was not the same as standing in someone else's body two thousand years after your own death.

A sound rang through the bridge.

Soft. Musical. Urgent.

Kael stopped.

The woman with the glass ring touched two fingers to her ear.

Her expression changed.

“What is it?” Kael asked.

“Public archive breach.”

Kael’s gaze snapped to Mara.

She stiffened. “I didn’t do anything.”

The woman listened, then looked at Eliya’s face with sudden unease.

“It’s not her current activity. It’s a release.”

“What release?” Kael asked.

The woman hesitated.

“Someone just opened the Sol family file.”

Eliya’s fear vanished.

In its place came something sharp enough to cut Mara from the inside.

“My family?” Eliya said.

This time the voice was hers.

Fully hers.

Kael noticed.

“Yes.”

“That file is sealed.”

“Not anymore.”

The bridge doors opened ahead, revealing a chamber of black glass and white light.

Inside stood a table shaped like a crescent. Above it floated images, documents, and moving faces. Mara recognized none of them.

Eliya recognized all of them.

A man with kind eyes.

A woman with silver beads braided into her hair.

A child laughing under blue ceiling-light.

Eliya's memories struck Mara in fragments.

Father.

Mother.

Brother.

Home.

Then one image turned.

It was not Eliya's family.

It was Mara.

Not a photograph from Geneva.

Not a mission portrait.

This was a statue. Older. Weathered. Carved in pale stone.

Mara's face stared from the floating image with eyes lifted toward a sky she had never seen.

Beneath it was an inscription in a language Eliya understood.

Mara did not want the translation.

It came anyway.

Mara Venn.

First Mother of the Uninvited.

Mara stared at the words until they blurred.

Eliya's voice trembled inside her.

What did you do to my family?

Mara had no answer.

Kael stepped beside them, his face grim.

“Now,” he said, “we find out who wanted you awake.”

DaintyHub